



Aviation Investigation Final Report

Location:	Old Bridge, New Jersey	Accident Number:	ERA23LA107
Date & Time:	January 1, 2023, 19:30 Local	Registration:	N8282K
Aircraft:	Piper PA-32R-301T	Aircraft Damage:	Substantial
Defining Event:	Controlled flight into terr/obj (CFIT)	Injuries:	1 None
Flight Conducted Under:	Part 91: General aviation - Personal		

Analysis

The purpose of the flight was for the pilot to stay in the airport traffic pattern and make two full-stop landings to meet night currency requirements. The pilot described that shortly after takeoff he encountered an unexpected indication while retracting the landing gear and that one of the navigation radios turned off and then back on again. He then extended the landing gear and subsequently noted no abnormal indication. He continued the in the traffic pattern and while on final approach to the runway noted that he was “low,” had a clear view of the runway, and did not see any trees or other obstructions. He then increased engine power before he heard the sounds of (trees) striking the airplane. He could see the runway in front of him, so he landed the airplane and taxied uneventfully to his hangar. Both of the airplane’s wings and horizontal stabilizers were substantially damaged. The pilot reported that there were no preaccident mechanical malfunctions or failures with the airplane that would have precluded normal operation.

Probable Cause and Findings

The National Transportation Safety Board determines the probable cause(s) of this accident to be:

The pilot’s failure to maintain adequate clearance from trees during the landing approach.

Findings

Personnel issues	Decision making/judgment - Pilot
Aircraft	Altitude - Not attained/maintained

Factual Information

History of Flight

Approach-VFR pattern final	Controlled flight into terr/obj (CFIT) (Defining event)
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Pilot Information

Certificate:	Private	Age:	55, Male
Airplane Rating(s):	Single-engine land	Seat Occupied:	Front
Other Aircraft Rating(s):	None	Restraint Used:	3-point
Instrument Rating(s):	Airplane	Second Pilot Present:	No
Instructor Rating(s):	None	Toxicology Performed:	
Medical Certification:	Class 3 Without waivers/limitations	Last FAA Medical Exam:	December 11, 2021
Occupational Pilot:	No	Last Flight Review or Equivalent:	May 19, 2022
Flight Time:	483 hours (Total, all aircraft), 154 hours (Total, this make and model), 316 hours (Pilot In Command, all aircraft), 7 hours (Last 90 days, all aircraft), 6 hours (Last 30 days, all aircraft)		

Aircraft and Owner/Operator Information

Aircraft Make:	Piper	Registration:	N8282K
Model/Series:	PA-32R-301T	Aircraft Category:	Airplane
Year of Manufacture:	1981	Amateur Built:	
Airworthiness Certificate:	Normal	Serial Number:	32R-8129002
Landing Gear Type:	Retractable - Tricycle	Seats:	6
Date/Type of Last Inspection:	May 23, 2022 Annual	Certified Max Gross Wt.:	3617 lbs
Time Since Last Inspection:	18 Hrs	Engines:	1 Reciprocating
Airframe Total Time:	3790 Hrs at time of accident	Engine Manufacturer:	Lycoming
ELT:	Installed, not activated	Engine Model/Series:	TIO-540-S1AD
Registered Owner:	On file	Rated Power:	300 Horsepower
Operator:	On file	Operating Certificate(s) Held:	None

Meteorological Information and Flight Plan

Conditions at Accident Site:	Visual (VMC)	Condition of Light:	Night/dark
Observation Facility, Elevation:	BLM,159 ft msl	Distance from Accident Site:	13 Nautical Miles
Observation Time:	18:56 Local	Direction from Accident Site:	131°
Lowest Cloud Condition:	Scattered / 8000 ft AGL	Visibility	10 miles
Lowest Ceiling:		Visibility (RVR):	
Wind Speed/Gusts:	6 knots / None	Turbulence Type Forecast/Actual:	None / None
Wind Direction:	250°	Turbulence Severity Forecast/Actual:	N/A / N/A
Altimeter Setting:	30.04 inches Hg	Temperature/Dew Point:	8°C / 5°C
Precipitation and Obscuration:	No Obscuration; No Precipitation		
Departure Point:	Old Bridge, NJ	Type of Flight Plan Filed:	None
Destination:	Old Bridge, NJ	Type of Clearance:	None
Departure Time:		Type of Airspace:	Class E

Airport Information

Airport:	OLD BRIDGE 3N6	Runway Surface Type:	Asphalt
Airport Elevation:	87 ft msl	Runway Surface Condition:	Dry
Runway Used:	24	IFR Approach:	None
Runway Length/Width:	3594 ft / 50 ft	VFR Approach/Landing:	Full stop;Traffic pattern

Wreckage and Impact Information

Crew Injuries:	1 None	Aircraft Damage:	Substantial
Passenger Injuries:	N/A	Aircraft Fire:	None
Ground Injuries:	N/A	Aircraft Explosion:	None
Total Injuries:	1 None	Latitude, Longitude:	40.333721,-74.342052(est)

Administrative Information

Investigator In Charge (IIC):	Wentz, Peter
Additional Participating Persons:	Watson Joseph ; FAA/FSDO; Teterboro, NJ
Original Publish Date:	June 15, 2023
Last Revision Date:	
Investigation Class:	Class 4
Note:	The NTSB did not travel to the scene of this accident.
Investigation Docket:	https://data.nts.gov/Docket?ProjectID=106560

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The NTSB does not assign fault or blame for an accident or incident; rather, as specified by NTSB regulation, “accident/incident investigations are fact-finding proceedings with no formal issues and no adverse parties ... and are not conducted for the purpose of determining the rights or liabilities of any person” (Title 49 *Code of Federal Regulations* section 831.4). Assignment of fault or legal liability is not relevant to the NTSB’s statutory mission to improve transportation safety by investigating accidents and incidents and issuing safety recommendations. In addition, statutory language prohibits the admission into evidence or use of any part of an NTSB report related to an accident in a civil action for damages resulting from a matter mentioned in the report (Title 49 *United States Code* section 1154(b)). A factual report that may be admissible under 49 *United States Code* section 1154(b) is available [here](#).